behavior, constraining their actions when public preferences are strongly felt.

Citizens also play a critical role in shaping the fortunes of IOs. Unlike states, IOs lack territory or military power; they derive much of their legitimacy and influence from public perception (Hurd 1999; Buchanan and Keohane 2006). When citizens lose faith in an IO, the institution's ability to enact meaningful change or fulfill its mission may be severely undermined. This makes public support a cornerstone of IOs' operational viability. Additionally, because public opinion can shape leaders' actions, IOs must be attuned to how they are perceived by domestic audiences.

That said, citizens often think very little about IOs in their day-to-day lives (at least in highly developed contexts; see Dolan and Milner 2023). For many, IOs exist on the periphery, overshadowed by the immediacy of personal and local concerns. However, during moments of heightened salience—such as financial crises, pandemics, wars, or other major global shocks—public attention shifts sharply toward these institutions. In such periods, IOs become prominent actors in the public consciousness, as their decisions directly affect citizens' lives and dominate news cycles. These moments of visibility can be both an opportunity and a challenge: Public opinion becomes a critical factor in determining whether IOs are perceived as trustworthy stewards of global governance or as dominated by out-of-touch elites. For IOs, maintaining favorable public opinion during such high-stakes moments is essential to safeguarding their legitimacy and effectiveness (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023).

2.4.4 Nonpopulist Leaders

Nonpopulist leaders of IO member states share a fundamental incentive with their populist counterparts—namely, the drive to retain power. This requires maintaining the support of constituents and interest groups while navigating their own ideological beliefs. However, nonpopulists are generally more inclined than populists to engage constructively with IOs and leverage the substantive benefits these institutions provide. Many nonpopulist leaders view international cooperation as a cornerstone of their governance philosophy, aligning with the missions of global institutions like the WTO, World Bank, IMF, and UN, which rely on the participation